

VICTOR'S SPOILS Gurwinder Singh Oberoi (centre) with CM Omar Abdullah and NC legislator Tanvir Sadiq; (inset) BJP's Sat Paul Sharma

ABID BHAT



SE, UPPER CUT

battles a surge of dissent after RS poll fiasco

ference bagged only three seats; its plans of a clean sweep were sabotaged by the Opposition BJP springing a surprise with a nail-biter on the fourth one. For the NC, Choudhary Mohammad Ramzan and Sajjad Ahmad Kichloo, a duo that had managed to flop even during their triumphant assembly poll outing, were the first to go through to Parliament.

KNOTS, CROSSES

The blip came in a third round that decided two seats. NC treasurer and Omar aide Gurwinder Singh Oberoi scraped through, but spokesperson Imran Nabi Dar came up short. Instead, BJP state unit chief and old-timer Sat Paul Sharma won with more votes than the party's strength in the House.

That's what raised temperatures on the non-BJP side. The NC, with 41 MLAs, had with it the Congress (6), PDP (3), one each of CPI(M), AAP and Awami Ittehad Party, plus five of six Independents. With 58 among 87 electors—Sajad Lone choosing to abstain—it should have been a cinch. But Sharma won, with three votes declared invalid and four MLAs cross-voting.

Who? The irate CM, Omar Abdullah, had no doubts. On October 24 evening, right after the results, he called it a betrayal by other parties, dismissing any chance of subversion within his own. "Does the BJP's secret team have the guts to put their hands up and own up to selling their souls after promising us?" he thundered, claiming to know the errant MLAs.

That, however, didn't wash even within the NC. Instead, it gave an opening for its bottled-up dissent to unspool a bit. Aga Ruhullah Mehdi, the voluble Srinagar MP, dared Omar to reveal the names, saying not doing so was itself a "betrayal of public trust". Not mincing words, he said: "This is not someone's private shop where such things can be hidden. This information is public property." Soon, the Gujjar MP from Anantnag-Rajouri, Mian Altaf Ahmad Larvi, was aiming barbs at Omar. He said the recruitment drive—central to the NC's promise of one lakh jobs—has failed to take off as expected, and cautioned the CM over his U-turn on smart electricity meters.

THE FRENEMIES

Omar's vocalised rage is in sync with the path he has evolved for a year, where friendship was always in danger of colliding with its opposite. The NC, formally with the INDIA bloc, began cultivating a distinct coolness towards the Congress right after fighting the 2024 assembly election together. A behavioural nuance seen as a bid to please the Centre, the idea is to not allow any hurdle in achieving Omar's larger goal of statehood—its endless deferment is his main source of grief.

Only a shell remains of the NC-Congress pact, crafted amid much bonding with Rahul Gandhi. No Congress MLA finds a place in Omar's ministry. Communication is scant; all essential dialogue is outsourced to his father, NC chief Farooq Abdullah, liaising with Sonia Gandhi in Delhi. The RS episode only turned that frenemy status shades darker. It was left to Farooq to try and cool tempers, shrugging off the fiasco as normal in politics and thanking everyone—from the Congress to the Independents. ■

Takeaways

- **J&K CM vents his ire against other parties after cross-voting thwarts an NC clean sweep of RS poll; only three win, BJP wrests an upset**
- **Two party MPs fire salvos against Omar, one implies subversion. The CM has kept up a harsh line on Congress to assuage New Delhi**